Commercial Office Vacancy | 2020–2026

Chronological, clickable bibliography · English-language reporting · Prepared October 29, 2026 · International focus (excluding U.S.)

Reading guidance. Evidence spans different markets and different kinds of measures: vacancy, leasing, occupancy, and remote-work policies. These are not interchangeable. Some jurisdictions show recovery in 2025–26 even while older or less desirable office buildings remain challenged. Avoid asserting that every company has permanently abandoned offices.

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01 | 2020-06-23 | Reuters | UK

Banks to cut office space in London after COVID - minister

Documented relevance: British financial services minister reported that some City of London banks expected to reduce square footage after extensive pandemic work-from-home adoption.

Early corporate space reduction

02 | 2020-06-27 | The Guardian | UK

Why the home-working boom could tumble London’s skyscrapers

Documented relevance: London consulting firm Bishopsgate said it would give up its central-city headquarters after remote work proved effective, saving hundreds of thousands of pounds annually.

Direct company example

03 | 2020-10-17 | Reuters | UK

Deloitte to shut four UK offices as COVID-19 entrenches remote working

Documented relevance: Deloitte announced closures in Gatwick, Liverpool, Nottingham and Southampton, with about 500 affected staff retaining jobs on permanent home-working contracts.

Confirmed office closures

04 | 2020-11-11 | Reuters | UK

Workspace swings to loss as customers downsize due to virus crisis

Documented relevance: London office landlord Workspace reported increased customer departures and downsizing, alongside a £110.4 million first-half pretax loss.

Landlord financial effects

05 | 2021-01-06 | Evening Standard | UK

Central London office lettings hit in WFH year, but demand improving

Documented relevance: Savills data indicated central London office take-up of 4.3 million square feet in 2020 versus 10.8 million in 2019, approximately 60% lower.

Leasing activity

06 | 2021-02-24 | The Guardian | UK

Lloyds embraces hybrid working with 20% cut in office space

Documented relevance: Lloyds planned to reduce office space by 20% over two years; 77% of surveyed staff wanted to work from home at least three days weekly.

Long-term space reduction

07 | 2021-03-25 | Reuters | UK

British banks slash office space, tell staff to “work anywhere”

Documented relevance: Nationwide told 13,000 office-based employees they could work anywhere in the country and planned not to renew leases on three Swindon offices.

Permanent hybrid policy / leases

08 | 2022-04-25 | Channel NewsAsia | Singapore

Majority of workers prefer to continue flexible work arrangements: IPS working paper

Documented relevance: A study of more than 2,000 workers found 41–52% favored flexible work as the new norm in surveyed periods, indicating lasting preference change, not directly a vacancy measurement.

Workplace behavior evidence

09 | 2023-04-10 | Bloomberg / Insurance Journal | Canada

Toronto Office Vacancies Hit 28-Year High as Remote Work Persists

Documented relevance: CBRE measured downtown Toronto vacancy of 15.3% in Q1 2023, highest since 1995; Canadian national office vacancy reached 17.7%.

Measured vacancy / remote work

10 | 2024-01-10 | Global News | Canada

Why Canada’s downtown office vacancy rate hit a record high to end 2023

Documented relevance: CBRE reported a record 19.4% national downtown office vacancy rate at year-end 2023; article examines remote work and other contributing factors.

Downtown vacancy record

11 | 2024-08-09 | The Guardian | Australia

Australian employers want staff in the office – but for many workers home is where the heart is

Documented relevance: Reports 14.6% average Australian CBD vacancy, 11.6% in Sydney CBD, and 19.4% in Parramatta amid return-to-office disputes.

Measured CBD vacancy

12 | 2024-09-23 | South China Morning Post | Hong Kong

Who’s to blame? Hong Kong office glut to worsen as developers add fresh supply in 2025

Documented relevance: CBRE estimated city-wide office vacancy at a record 17%, while about 3 million square feet of new supply were expected in 2025.

Oversupply / measured vacancy

13 | 2024-10-02 | Reuters | UK

London’s Canary Wharf sets sights on hotels to fill empty offices

Documented relevance: Vacancy in Docklands, including Canary Wharf, approached 17% in September 2024 versus roughly 4% in 2017; owners explored hotel and other conversions.

Adaptive reuse / vacancy trend

14 | 2025-02-18 | Reuters | Germany / EU

ECB extends work from home policy even as others reverse course

Documented relevance: European Central Bank extended permission to work remotely up to 110 days annually for two years; 95% of its staff used the option. This establishes persistence, not office vacancy.

Institutional hybrid policy

15 | 2025-03-24 | South China Morning Post | Hong Kong

Hong Kong may need 7 to 15 years to digest city's glut of commercial space, experts say

Documented relevance: Reports roughly 15 million square feet of excess office space; CBRE and S&P analysts estimated seven to fifteen years to absorb the glut under stated assumptions.

Structural oversupply forecast

16 | 2026-01-07 | The Canadian Press / CityNews | Canada

Office vacancy rate dips as return-to-office shift picks up: CBRE report

Documented relevance: CBRE measured national vacancy at 18% at year-end 2025 versus 10.9% at year-end 2019, despite a recent improvement from 18.7%.

Pre- / post-pandemic comparison

17 | 2026-03-01 | South China Morning Post | Hong Kong

Hong Kong's small office landlords turn to co-working, student hostels to survive

Documented relevance: Examines conversion of aging office properties as tenants gravitate to newer premium buildings, with significant new office deliveries expected.

Adaptive reuse / asset obsolescence

18 | 2026-07-09 | The Canadian Press / ConstructConnect | Canada

Office market sees one year of recovery following pandemic-induced disruption: CBRE

Documented relevance: Canadian office vacancy declined to 17.1% in Q2 2026 from 18.7% a year earlier, but lower-grade space remained more challenged than trophy buildings.

Measured recovery / segmentation

19 | 2026-08-06 | Commercial Real Estate Australia | Australia

National office vacancy rate hits 16.1% as empty space reaches post-pandemic high

Documented relevance: Property Council of Australia measured 16.1% national vacancy in June 2026, the highest since the COVID era and early-1990s recession; non-CBD vacancy was 18.9%.

National post-pandemic vacancy high